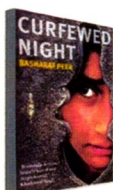


A Valley in Memory

Basharat Peer seeks out ordinary Kashmiris to tell the story of a lost world



CURFEWED NIGHT
by BASHARAT PEER
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By Gillian Wright

Somewhere in *Curfewed Night*, Basharat Peer explains why he wrote this book. "People from almost every conflict zone had told their stories... I felt the absence of our own telling, the unwritten books about the Kashmiri experience... as vividly as the absence of a beloved." So he set out to record his memories and revisit the people and places that had haunted him since 1989 when the Vale of Kashmir lost its peace. Peer brilliantly evokes the idyllic world of his early childhood, the spontaneity of the anti-India protests and the constant fear, humiliation and loss that have characterised the Kashmiri experience since then. Thirteen-years old then, he found militancy glamorous. Only timely persuasion by his family prevented Peer from going over the border himself.

To keep him safe, Peer's father sent him to Delhi University for further studies, where he discovered an India he could appreciate. Boys he knew did join the militants. Their lives were generally short. Peer tracks down one who survived and who describes how he had hated forcing

himself into homes where families sheltered him simply out of fear. As *Curfewed Night* is a personal account, it is easier to relate to than the news coverage of blasts and killings that are the main source of information for those outside the Valley. Peer has an innate compassion, part of the traditional Kashmiri culture, and this complements his professional ability as a journalist to tell his stories without embellishment. Not that any of them require embellishment—a bride shot and then gang-raped by paramilitary forces, his own parents nearly assassinated by militants, or peaceful protesters shot down on one of Srinagar's medieval wooden bridges.

Peer seeks out ordinary Kashmiris. He takes pains to illustrate the long-term impact on individual lives of being involved in the conflict of the last 20 years. His book could easily have degenerated into a list of woes. It does not because he makes everyone he meets three-dimensional human beings that a reader can empathise with as much as he does. He has no sympathy for acts of brutality, whether by militants or security forces. He feels deeply the damage done to Kashmiri culture by the targeting of the Pandit community. He travels to Jammu to meet old friends, now living as refugees. But mostly, he talks to Kashmiri Muslims who have found themselves trapped between the militants and security forces.

Many of the thousands of people who have disappeared, been tortured or killed since 1989 were innocent. One of the most shocking stories in the book is about a teenager, Gulzar, who was forced by the army to carry a mine into a house full of militants. The mine exploded, killing him and the militants. Gulzar was one of Peer's cousins. He writes, "After Gulzar's death, nobody talked about getting justice, fighting in a court to get punishment for the soldiers who killed Gulzar. Those things happen elsewhere, in countries where the law is implemented: in Kashmir, you try to save the living from further trouble." Instead of fighting for justice, the family accepted a government job for Gulzar's brother. *Curfewed Night* offers no solutions to the Kashmir problem but this is not its aim. Peer is a bridge-builder and Kashmir needs people to build bridges of awareness and understanding. Force alone can never answer difficult questions like those posed by Kashmir. ■



SAURABH SINGH